

Why Local Search Is Going AI — And What That Means for Your Business

The shift that's already happened, why 98.8% of local businesses are missing it, and the exact landscape you're working with in 2026.

By the end of this guide you'll understand exactly how AI-powered local search works, which platforms matter, why traditional Google rankings aren't enough any more, and what the businesses getting recommended by ChatGPT and Perplexity are doing differently.

What you'll learn in this guide

This is Module 1 of 5 in the Get Found in AI Local Search series. It's the foundation — the "why" before the "how". By the time you finish, you'll have a clear picture of what's changed, why it matters, and what the path forward looks like.

1

Understand the AI local search shift

Know exactly how AI search has changed local business discovery — with the real numbers from 2026 so you understand the scale of what's happening.

2

Know which AI platforms matter for local businesses

Learn the six platforms actively sending customers to local businesses right now — and how each one works differently.

3

Understand the rating thresholds that filter you out

Discover the minimum star ratings each AI platform requires before it'll recommend a business — and what that means practically.

4

Learn the three signals AI uses to decide who to recommend

The data signals AI platforms trust most — and why only 1.2% of local businesses are currently passing all three.

5

Know exactly what to do next

Leave this module with a clear understanding of the path through Modules 2–5, so you can start work immediately.

This guide is written for people who are brilliant at what they do but haven't had to think about AI search before. No jargon without explanation. Every concept gets a real-world analogy before the technical detail. Let's get into it.

Introduction: The shift that's already happened

Something has changed in how people find local businesses, and most business owners haven't noticed yet — which is either terrible news or a significant opportunity, depending on how quickly you act.

Eighteen months ago, when someone wanted a plumber, a dentist, or a dog groomer, they did one of two things: they asked a friend, or they typed it into Google. Today, a growing number of them are doing something different: they're asking an AI assistant. "Hey ChatGPT, who's the best electrician near me?" or "Find me a family restaurant in Bristol with good reviews." And the AI gives them one or two names.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

It used to be like a phone directory where you competed to appear on the right page. Now it's more like having a well-connected local expert — someone who knows your town, reads all the reviews, and has heard about every business — and that expert is making personal recommendations to hundreds of thousands of people every day. Being on their list is enormously valuable. Being off it is increasingly costly.

The numbers tell the story clearly. AI usage for local search jumped from 6% of all local searches in 2025 to 45% in 2026. That's a 7.5x increase in a single year. AI search traffic overall grew by 527%. These aren't small shifts — they're seismic ones, happening faster than almost any technology change in search history.

The visibility gap no one is talking about

Here's the part that should stop you in your tracks. ChatGPT recommends just **1.2% of local businesses** when asked for local recommendations. Google, by comparison, shows 35.9% of local businesses in its local pack. That means for every 100 businesses that appear on Google's local results, only about 3 appear when someone asks ChatGPT the same question.

1.2%

of local businesses
recommended by ChatGPT

35.9%

of local businesses appear in
Google's local pack

45%

of local searches now use AI (up
from 6% in 2025)

This gap exists for a reason. AI systems are fundamentally more selective than traditional search engines — not because they're trying to be difficult, but because they're doing something different. They're not showing you a list of options. They're making a recommendation. And they only recommend things they're confident about.

The good news: the businesses currently in that 1.2% aren't there by accident or by spending more money. They're there because their online presence is set up in a way that AI systems can understand, verify, and trust. And that's entirely achievable for any local business — which is what this series is about.

THE WINDOW IS OPEN NOW

Most of your local competitors are not thinking about AI visibility yet. The businesses that set up correctly in the next six months will be embedded in AI recommendations before their competitors even know this conversation is happening. That window won't stay open long.

How AI local search actually works

Understanding how AI platforms decide who to recommend is the most important thing in this entire guide. Once you get this, everything else in the series will make perfect sense. So let's spend a bit of time here.

It's not a search — it's a synthesis

When someone types "best plumber near me" into Google, Google matches those words against its index of web pages and returns results ranked by relevance and authority. You appear in the results based on your website, your GBP, your location, and dozens of other signals.

When someone asks ChatGPT or Perplexity "who's the best plumber in my area?", something quite different happens. The AI doesn't just match words to pages. It synthesises everything it knows about local plumbers from multiple sources — its training data, live web browsing, review data, and structured business information — and then makes a judgment call about who to recommend.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

AI search is like asking a really well-read local expert who's been obsessively reading Google reviews, local forums, Reddit, local newspaper features, and business directories for years. They don't just give you a list — they tell you who they'd actually send their own family to. The businesses they recommend are the ones where the evidence is consistent, clear, and comes from multiple independent sources.

This is why you can rank #1 on Google for "plumber Sheffield" and still be completely invisible when someone asks ChatGPT the same question. The two systems are looking at overlapping but fundamentally different evidence.

What AI platforms are actually looking at

Different AI platforms have different primary data sources, but all of them are doing some version of the same thing: looking for consistent, trustworthy signals about your business from multiple independent places. Here's what they're drawing from:

- ✓ **Your Google Business Profile** — The most structured, verified local business data available. For local search, this is the spine that Google's AI Overviews, Gemini, and ChatGPT (via web search) all read.
- ✓ **Review platforms** — Not just star ratings. The text of reviews, the recency of reviews, how you respond to them, and whether reviews appear across multiple platforms (not just Google).
- ✓ **Your website** — Specifically: how clearly your site states what you do, where you serve, and who you're for. Vague websites give AI nothing to work with.
- ✓ **Business directories and listings** — Yell, Yelp, Bing Places, Apple Maps, and industry-specific directories. The key here is consistency — your Name, Address, and Phone must match across all of them.
- ✓ **Editorial and community mentions** — Local press, industry publications, Reddit discussions, community Facebook groups (when publicly indexed). Independent third-party mentions carry significant trust weight.
- ✓ **Social profiles** — Active, linked, and consistently named across Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn, and X. An inactive social profile is a weak signal; an active one contributes to entity confidence.

HEADS UP

AI systems are looking for the same signal from multiple independent sources. If everything positive about your business only exists on your own website and your own Google Business Profile, that's only two sources saying the same thing — not enough for an AI to make a confident recommendation.

The concept of "entity confidence"

There's a term worth knowing: **entity confidence**. It refers to how certain an AI system is that your business is who you say you are, does what you say you do, and is trusted by the people around you.

Think of it like a credit score for your business's online identity. A high entity confidence score means the AI has found consistent, corroborated information about you from multiple trustworthy sources, and it's confident recommending you. A low score means the information is patchy, inconsistent, or only appears in one or two places.

The things that build entity confidence are straightforward:

- 1 Consistent business name across every platform.** "Smith's Plumbing Ltd" should be exactly that, everywhere — not "Smiths Plumbing" on Facebook and "Smith and Sons Plumbers" on a directory listing from 2018.
- 2 Consistent address and phone number.** Even small variations — a different phone format, "Street" vs "St" — create noise that lowers confidence.
- 3 Reviews that say specific things about specific services.** "Great emergency plumber, came within an hour and fixed the leak" builds more confidence than "5 stars, would recommend."
- 4 Mentions from independent sources that agree with each other.** Local press, directories, and community mentions all saying the same thing about your business compound into high confidence.

QUICK WIN

Right now, search your own business name on Google and look at the first two pages. Write down every place you appear. Check whether your business name, address, and phone number are identical everywhere. Any inconsistency you find is reducing your entity confidence score with AI systems.

Training data vs live browsing — why it matters

Different AI platforms get their information in different ways, and this affects how quickly you can influence what they say about you.

Training data: ChatGPT's core knowledge comes from a massive training dataset — essentially a snapshot of a large portion of the internet up to a certain date. This means what ChatGPT "knows" about your business is partly based on what existed online before that cutoff. Changes you make today won't instantly appear in its training-based responses.

Live browsing: ChatGPT now browses the live web for many queries (this expanded significantly in its May 2026 update), Perplexity always browses the live web, and Google's AI Overviews are powered by live index data. For these queries, changes you make to your website, GBP, and online profiles can be reflected in AI responses much faster — sometimes within days.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

Training data is like the knowledge a friend has from years of living in your town. Live browsing is like them searching the web fresh for your question right now. For local business recommendations, more and more AI queries are doing the "fresh search" — which means your current online presence matters more than ever.

The practical implication: for Perplexity-style recommendations, you can see results quickly from improving your website and GBP. For training-data-based ChatGPT responses, building your cross-platform presence over months is the longer game that pays off more permanently.

HEADS UP

Even for training data, your online presence matters — because AI models are continually updated and refined. Building your presence now means being in the data for the next update cycle.

The six AI platforms that matter for local businesses

Not all AI platforms are equally relevant for local business recommendations. Here are the six you should know about and what each one means for you.

ChatGPT **OPENAI**

Largest user base. Historically low local citation rate (1.2%) but improving rapidly with live browsing. May 2026 update significantly increased website links in responses.

Google AI Overviews **GOOGLE**

Now on 48% of searches. Pulls directly from Google Business Profile. Being cited here gets 120% more clicks per impression than standard results.

Perplexity **PERPLEXITY AI**

13.05% citation rate — 22x higher than ChatGPT. Always live-browses. Fast-growing user base. Most responsive to page structure improvements.

Gemini **GOOGLE**

Google's AI assistant. Lower minimum star rating requirement (3.90 vs ChatGPT's 4.30). Draws from Google's index and GBP data.

Microsoft Copilot **MICROSOFT / BING**

Powers Bing search results. Draws from Bing index and Bing Places. Important for any business not fully set up on Bing's ecosystem.

Meta AI **META**

Embedded in Facebook, Instagram, and WhatsApp. Grows in relevance as users ask it for local recommendations inside social apps they're already using.

You don't need to approach each of these differently to start. The foundation work — good GBP, consistent NAP, reviews on multiple platforms, a clear website — feeds all of them.

Which platforms to prioritise and why

If you have limited time (and who doesn't), focus in this order:

- 1 Google AI Overviews first.** This is where the volume is. 48% of Google searches now trigger an AI Overview. Your Google Business Profile is the primary data source for this. Getting this right benefits the biggest audience immediately, and the same work feeds Gemini automatically.
- 2 Perplexity second.** The highest citation rate of any AI platform (13.05%), responsive to page structure improvements, and its user base is growing fast — particularly among people aged 25-45 who are actively seeking alternatives to traditional search. The work that helps Perplexity (clear content structure, fast website, credible mentions) is good foundation work for everything else too.
- 3 ChatGPT third.** Enormous user base means even a 1.2% citation rate represents significant reach. Since the May 2026 update, improving your website for live browsing queries is increasingly worthwhile. Cross-platform presence building benefits ChatGPT's training-data responses over time.
- 4 Bing Places / Microsoft Copilot fourth.** Many local businesses are not even listed on Bing Places — which means they're invisible to Microsoft Copilot by default. This takes 20 minutes to fix and is low-competition for most local categories.
- 5 Meta AI fifth.** Follow-on from having active Facebook and Instagram profiles. No specific additional work needed beyond keeping your social profiles accurate and active.

THE GOOD NEWS

You're not doing separate work for each platform. The foundation — GBP, NAP consistency, reviews, clear website — is shared infrastructure that feeds all of them. You build it once and it compounds across every AI platform simultaneously.

The rating thresholds that filter you out

One of the most surprising findings in AI local search research in 2026 is how strict AI platforms are about star ratings. They have minimum thresholds below which they simply won't recommend a business — no matter how well-optimised everything else is.

This is intuitive when you think about it. An AI assistant making a personal recommendation to a user won't suggest a business with a 3.2-star average — that would feel like a terrible recommendation and erode trust in the AI. So the platforms have implicit (and increasingly explicit) minimum rating floors.

AI Platform	Minimum Rating Threshold	What This Means
ChatGPT	★ 4.30+	The strictest threshold. Even a single run of negative reviews can push you below this and out of recommendations.
Perplexity	★ 4.10+	Slightly more lenient, but still above what many businesses achieve.
Google AI Overviews	★ 4.00+	Aligns with Google's general quality signals for local pack inclusion.
Gemini	★ 3.90+	The most accessible threshold — but still above the UK average for many service industries.

HEADS UP

These thresholds apply to your Google review rating. If your rating is currently below 4.0, getting AI recommendations is not impossible — but actively gathering positive reviews is an urgent priority, not a nice-to-have. A single bad month of reviews can drop you below threshold and out of AI recommendations.

What AI reads in your reviews (beyond the star rating)

The star rating threshold is the entry requirement. But AI systems also read the *content* of reviews to understand what your business does, how well it does it, and whether specific claims are verifiable. This shapes not just whether you get recommended, but *how* you get recommended.

When a customer writes "fantastic plumber, came within 90 minutes on a Saturday, fixed the boiler and explained exactly what was wrong," the AI extracts several useful data points: speed of response, emergency availability, service type (boiler), professionalism (explanation). This kind of specific review makes the AI more confident recommending you for those specific scenarios.

When a customer writes "great service, five stars," the AI gets almost nothing usable beyond the star rating itself.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

Imagine the AI is building a profile of your business from everything customers have written. Specific reviews are like case studies — they add detail and build the profile. Generic reviews are like character references that say "seems like a good person" without any specifics. One detailed case study is worth five generic references.

This has a practical implication for how you ask for reviews. Asking customers to "leave a Google review" is fine but misses an opportunity. Asking them to "write a few words about which service they used and how it went" steers them toward the kind of specific review that builds your AI profile more effectively.

REVIEW REQUEST SCRIPT

"Hi [Name], thanks again for choosing us for [service]. Would you mind leaving us a quick Google review? Even a couple of sentences about what we did and how it went makes a real difference for us. Here's the link: [link]"

The three signals AI uses to decide who to recommend

Research into AI local search behaviour in 2026 has identified three primary categories of signal that AI systems weight most heavily when making local business recommendations. Understanding these gives you a map of where to invest your time.

1

Entity clarity — being unambiguously identifiable

The AI must be able to clearly identify that your business is a single, consistent entity. This means your business name, address, phone number, and description should be letter-perfect identical across every place you appear online. Inconsistency fractures your identity in the AI's understanding — it treats "Smith's Plumbing Ltd" and "Smiths Plumbing" as potentially different businesses.

2

Corroboration — being verified by independent sources

A single source saying good things about you carries little weight. Multiple independent sources — Google reviews, Trustpilot, local press, Reddit mentions, directory listings, social profiles — all saying the same positive thing about you builds the AI's confidence dramatically. This "triangulation from independent sources" is the most powerful trust signal of all.

3

Structured data clarity — being readable by machines

AI systems extract information from structured sources more easily than from unstructured text. A fully completed Google Business Profile, with all categories filled in, is structured data. A well-organised website with schema markup is structured data. Specific reviews that name the service and location are semi-structured. The more structured your business information is, the easier it is for AI to extract, trust, and cite you.

How the three signals work together

These signals don't operate in isolation — they compound. Think of it like building a legal case. Entity clarity is having a clear, consistent identity (so the AI knows who you are). Corroboration is having multiple independent witnesses (so the AI knows others trust you). Structured data is having the evidence presented in a format the AI can read and understand (so the AI can act on it efficiently).

Missing one of the three weakens the other two. A business with perfect entity clarity and great structured data but no third-party corroboration is like a witness who knows exactly who they are but has no other witnesses to back their account. The AI can identify you, but can't confidently vouch for you.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

Imagine you're going to a new city and asking a local for a restaurant recommendation. You'd feel most confident if they said: "It's called The Oak — I know exactly where it is, I've been there three times, my colleagues have been there, there's a feature in the local paper, and it has 4.7 stars on Google." That's all three signals firing together. An AI recommendation works the same way.

The 1.2% who are already passing all three

The local businesses currently getting recommended by ChatGPT aren't big brands with marketing departments. They're typically businesses that have — often without knowing the AI implication — maintained a clean, consistent online presence for years. They've kept their GBP updated, responded to every review, kept directory listings accurate, and maintained an active website. Their entity confidence is high because they've been building it for years without realising it was a competitive asset.

The businesses that aren't recommended are typically ones where the online presence was set up once and never revisited. Directory listings from 2015 with the old address. A GBP that hasn't been updated since it was claimed. Reviews from four years ago with nothing recent.

The path from the 98.8% to the 1.2% is about systematically working through each of the three signals. Modules 2 through 5 of this series take you through that path step by step.

Why traditional Google rankings aren't enough any more

This is the part that catches most business owners off guard, because the instinct is: "If I rank well on Google, I should be fine." In 2024, that was broadly true. In 2026, it's no longer sufficient on its own.

The "position zero" problem

Google now places an AI Overview above the traditional blue-link results for roughly 48% of searches. This AI Overview often answers the user's question so completely that they don't click any of the links below it. Research shows that when an AI Overview appears, traditional organic results see click-through rates drop by 30-40%.

Ranking #1 in the blue links is still valuable. But if an AI Overview appears above you and doesn't mention your business — while mentioning a competitor — you're functionally invisible to a significant portion of searchers even though you're technically "number one."

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

Imagine your shop is on the best corner of the high street — prime location, good footfall. But then a brand-new recommendation kiosk opens right at the entrance to the street, and it's directing everyone to different shops before they even get to your corner. You're still in the best spot on the street, but a meaningful portion of shoppers are being sent elsewhere before they reach you.

The new game: being cited, not ranked

The goal in 2026 isn't just to rank — it's to be cited. Being cited inside an AI Overview earns approximately 120% more clicks per impression than being in the standard results below it. A business cited in position one of an AI Overview is getting more traffic than the business ranked #1 in traditional results on the same query.

Does traditional SEO still matter?

Yes — but as one input into a larger system rather than the only thing that matters. Traditional SEO gives you:

- ✓ **Google local pack visibility** — Still valuable and still gets clicks, particularly on mobile where the map results are prominent.
- ✓ **Website traffic from traditional searches** — The traditional blue-link results aren't disappearing, just declining in share for some query types.
- ✓ **A crawlable, indexed site** — Which is also what AI systems need to be able to read and cite you in real-time browsing queries.

Good SEO practice — a fast website, clear content structure, quality backlinks, accurate GBP — is also good GEO practice (Generative Engine Optimisation). They're not in conflict. The issue is that SEO alone is no longer sufficient: the AI search layer requires additional work on cross-platform presence and structured data that traditional SEO doesn't address.

25%

predicted drop in traditional search volume by end of 2026

527%

increase in AI search traffic in 12 months

120%

more clicks from AI Overview citations vs standard results

THE KEY INSIGHT

You're not choosing between SEO and GEO. You're extending your SEO foundation to include the additional signals that AI systems need. The work in this series builds on what you may already be doing — it doesn't replace it.

Where most local businesses go wrong right now

Before we look at the specific fixes in Modules 2-5, it's worth understanding the common patterns that keep most local businesses out of AI recommendations. Recognising your own situation in these patterns helps you know where to focus first.

Mistake 1: Set it and forget it

The most common pattern. A Google Business Profile was claimed in 2019, filled in with the basics, and never touched again. The business has since moved premises, changed its phone number, updated its service offering, and taken on new team members. The GBP shows the old address, old number, a photo of the previous premises, and no posts in three years.

To a human searcher, this might be confusing but manageable — they'd call or visit the website to verify. To an AI system, this is a red flag. Outdated, inconsistent information lowers entity confidence, not raises it.

CHECK RIGHT NOW

Log into your Google Business Profile and look at your last post, your last review response, and your current photos. When were they? If any of these are more than 60 days ago, your GBP activity signals are weakening.

Mistake 2: Reviews only on Google

Google reviews matter enormously. But a business with 47 Google reviews and nothing on any other platform has only one independent source of social proof. AI systems looking for corroboration across multiple independent platforms will find only one. The same business with 47 Google reviews, 12 Trustpilot reviews, and 8 Facebook recommendations has three independent sources — dramatically higher corroboration confidence.

Mistake 3: A vague website

The most common website problem for local businesses is not technical — it's editorial. The homepage says something like "Welcome to Smith's Plumbing. We provide high-quality plumbing services to our customers" without ever mentioning where (which town or region) or what specifically (boiler installations? emergency callouts? bathroom fitting?).

To a human reader, this is slightly underwhelming but they'd click around to find out more. To an AI system scanning the page for citation-worthy information, there's nothing specific enough to extract and use. The AI can't confidently say "Smith's Plumbing in Sheffield specialises in emergency callouts and boiler installations" because the website never actually said that.

The fix is simple but requires rewriting: your homepage first paragraph should state your town, your primary service, and your main customer promise within the first two sentences. That's it. Every word you add of specific, local, service-specific content is a signal the AI can use.

Mistake 4: Inconsistent NAP (Name, Address, Phone)

This is the silent killer of entity confidence. A business might have its correct details on its website and GBP, but then have old details on Yell, a slightly different name on Yelp, and a no-longer-active number on a directory from 2017. Each inconsistency is a small confidence deduction. Multiple inconsistencies across multiple platforms add up to a business that AI systems aren't confident recommending.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

Imagine someone giving witness testimony in court who keeps slightly changing their name and address each time they're asked. "John Smith, 12 Oak Street." "Jon Smith, 12 Oak Street." "J. Smith, 12 Oak Road." Is this the same person? Maybe — but it introduces doubt. That doubt is exactly what lowers entity confidence for AI systems.

Mistake 5: No presence outside your own channels

Everything about your business exists only on platforms you control: your website, your GBP, your Facebook page. There are no independent editorial mentions, no forum discussions, no press coverage, no industry association listings. Nothing that a genuinely independent third party has said about you.

AI systems are specifically looking for corroboration from sources that you *don't* control — because those are the ones that can't be gamed. A local press article, a mention in a community Facebook group (indexed and publicly accessible), a listing in a vetted industry association directory — these carry disproportionate weight precisely because you couldn't just add them yourself.

Building this kind of presence takes time and can't be rushed — which is exactly why starting now beats waiting. One local press mention this quarter, consistently sought, compounds over two years into a very different level of AI authority than starting two years from now.

Mistake 6: Not on Bing Places

This one surprises people: a significant number of local businesses are not set up on Bing Places for Business at all. Since Microsoft Copilot — which is increasingly integrated into Windows and Office tools — draws local recommendations from Bing's index, this means they're completely invisible to that platform. Setting up Bing Places takes about 20 minutes and is a free, quick win with surprisingly low competition in most local categories.

QUICK WIN

Search "Bing Places for Business" and set up your listing today if you haven't already. It's free, takes 20 minutes, and most local businesses in your category haven't done it yet.

What the 1.2% are doing that you're not (yet)

Let's flip the perspective. Rather than looking at what most businesses get wrong, let's look at the common patterns in local businesses that do get recommended by AI search engines.

They treat their GBP like a living document

The businesses getting AI recommendations don't treat their Google Business Profile as something you set up once. They add new photos every couple of weeks. They post updates regularly — a new service, a seasonal promotion, a completed job they're proud of. They respond to every review within 48 hours. They use the Q&A section to pre-answer common questions.

All of this generates engagement signals (photo views, profile visits, Q&A interactions) that tell Google's AI the business is active, real, and worth recommending.

They actively spread their reviews across platforms

Instead of just asking for Google reviews, they ask different customers to leave reviews on different platforms. "Would you mind leaving us a Trustpilot review?" for some customers. "Would a Facebook recommendation work for you?" for others. Over time, they build a spread of consistent positive feedback across three or four independent platforms — exactly the corroboration AI systems look for.

Their website says the specific things clearly

Within the first two sentences of their homepage, you know what they do, where they serve, and who they're for. Every service they offer has its own clear description. Their location (town, postcodes served, surrounding areas) is mentioned explicitly in the main content — not hidden in the footer. This gives AI systems extractable, specific, citable information.

They've built (or found themselves with) third-party mentions

Whether through deliberate effort or just being in business for a while and being good at it, the businesses getting AI recommendations tend to have mentions beyond their own channels. A local paper article. A feature in an industry newsletter. Membership and listing in a trade body. A quote in a "best local services" roundup. Genuine discussion on a local Facebook group or forum.

These don't have to be large or prominent. A mention in the local business magazine's new business section. A quote in a trade publication about a technique they use. A listing on the Federation of Master Builders website. The key is independence — these are sources they don't directly control.

Their name is identical everywhere

Search any of the top AI-recommended businesses in a local category and check their name across platforms. It'll be identical — not just similar. This consistency, built up over years of maintaining accurate listings, has accumulated into high entity confidence that no newer business can replicate quickly.

The good news: if you start now, you can build this in months rather than years, because you're being intentional about it. The businesses that have it didn't necessarily plan it — they just happened to keep things consistent. You can be deliberate about it from day one.

THE COMPOUND EFFECT

Every consistent listing, every new review on a different platform, every editorial mention adds to your entity confidence. It doesn't have to be perfect to start working — it just has to be moving in the right direction. Start today, and six months from now you'll have a presence that's months ahead of competitors who wait until AI recommendations feel inevitable.

Your roadmap through this series

Now that you understand the landscape, here's exactly what's coming in Modules 2 through 5 — and why the order matters.

- 1 Module 2: Your Google Business Profile — The AI Visibility Powerhouse**
The single most important thing a local business can do for AI search visibility. We go through every section of your GBP, explain what each field does for AI visibility, and leave you with a fully optimised profile. Includes the Q&A, posts, photos, and engagement tactics that keep your profile's activity signals high.
- 2 Module 3: Reviews, Trust Signals and Cross-Platform Presence**
Building the corroboration layer that AI systems trust. How to ask for reviews strategically, which platforms matter, how to audit and fix your directory listings, and how to start building the editorial mentions that carry the highest weight with AI systems.
- 3 Module 4: Your Website and Content — Structured for AI Citation**
Rewriting your website's key pages so AI systems can extract specific, citable information. Covers the structure of a GEO-ready homepage and service pages, the content elements that make AI systems confident citing you, and basic schema markup that gives AI structured signals to work with.
- 4 Module 5: Your 30-Day AI Visibility Action Plan**
One focused task per day across the 30 days. Baseline measurement on day one. Review on day 30. The plan brings together everything from Modules 2-4 into a sequenced, time-estimated implementation that actually gets done.

Each module stands alone if you need to jump to a specific area. But they work best in sequence — each one builds on the foundation of the previous. We recommend starting from Module 2 if you've finished this one.

Five quick wins to do today

Before you move to Module 2, here are five things you can do right now — in under 90 minutes total — that will start improving your AI visibility today.

- 1 Search your business name on Google (not logged in, ideally from a different device).** Write down every place you appear on pages 1-3. Note any inconsistencies in your name, address, or phone number. This is your audit starting point.

Time: 15 minutes

- 2 Log into your Google Business Profile.** Check when you last added a photo, last posted, and last responded to a review. If any of these are more than 30 days ago, respond to the most recent unresponded review right now and add one new photo.

Time: 10 minutes

- 3 Search yourself on Perplexity and ChatGPT.** Ask "Who is the best [your service] in [your town]?" and see what comes up. If it's not you, note who is — that's your benchmark.

Time: 10 minutes

- 4 Check your star rating.** If it's below 4.3, start drafting a personal text or email to your three most recent satisfied customers asking for an honest Google review. Send it today.

Time: 15 minutes

- 5 Check whether you're on Bing Places.** Go to bingplaces.com and search your business. If you're not there, start the setup. It's free and takes 20 minutes.

Time: 20 minutes

None of these are the full solution — that's what Modules 2-5 are for. But each one moves you in the right direction and gives you a clearer picture of where you are right now.

Module 1 — Quick wins checklist

Use this as your end-of-module check. Tick each item as you complete it.

UNDERSTANDING

- ☐ I understand why AI local search is different from traditional Google rankings
- ☐ I know that ChatGPT recommends only 1.2% of local businesses — and why
- ☐ I understand the three signals AI uses: entity clarity, corroboration, and structured data
- ☐ I know my minimum star rating target (4.30 for ChatGPT, 4.10 for Perplexity)

AUDIT DONE

- ☐ I've searched my business name on Google and noted where I appear
- ☐ I've noted any NAP inconsistencies in my listings
- ☐ I've searched for myself on Perplexity and ChatGPT and noted the results
- ☐ I know my current Google star rating and review count

QUICK ACTIONS

- ☐ I've logged into my GBP and checked recency of photos, posts, and review responses
- ☐ I've responded to any unanswered reviews in my GBP
- ☐ I've texted or emailed 3 recent customers to ask for a Google review
- ☐ I've checked whether I'm on Bing Places (and set it up if not)

READY FOR MODULE 2

- ☐ I understand what Module 2 covers and why GBP is the highest-priority place to start
- ☐ I have access to my Google Business Profile login

What's next

You now understand the landscape: what's changed, why it matters, and where most local businesses are going wrong. That's the foundation. Module 2 is where the practical implementation begins.

COMING NEXT — MODULE 2 OF 5

Your Google Business Profile — The AI Visibility Powerhouse

Your GBP is the single most important piece of infrastructure for AI local search visibility. It feeds Google AI Overviews, Gemini, and ChatGPT's live browsing — all at once. Module 2 takes you through every section, explains exactly what each field contributes to AI recommendations, and leaves you with a fully optimised profile that's working as hard as it can for you. We cover the often-missed sections (Q&A, attributes, services), the engagement tactics that build activity signals, and the photo strategy that makes a real difference. After Module 2, your GBP will be doing more work for you than it ever has.

If you have questions about anything in Module 1, or you're getting stuck on one of the quick wins, the [AI Search School community](#) is the place to get them answered. It's free to join and this stuff gets discussed in real time as the platforms change.

See you in Module 2.

— Chris, AI Search School

Resources and further reading

Tools mentioned in this guide

- ✓ **Google Business Profile** — business.google.com — Free. Claim, verify, and manage your GBP. Essential starting point.
- ✓ **Bing Places for Business** — bingplaces.com — Free. The Bing equivalent of GBP. Essential for Microsoft Copilot visibility.
- ✓ **Perplexity** — perplexity.ai — Search for yourself and your competitors to see how AI search currently represents your category.
- ✓ **ChatGPT** — chatgpt.com — Ask it local business recommendation questions to see what comes up for your category.
- ✓ **Google's Rich Results Test** — search.google.com/test/rich-results — Check whether your website has any structured data that search engines and AI can use.

Key stats in this guide (sources)

- ✓ AI usage for local search: 6% (2025) → 45% (2026) — Local Business AI Search research, 2026
- ✓ ChatGPT recommends 1.2% of local businesses vs Google local pack's 35.9% — Evolve AMZ Research, 2026
- ✓ AI Overviews on 48% of tracked queries — SeoProfy AI Overviews Statistics, 2026
- ✓ Citations in AI Overviews earn 120% more clicks — BrightLocal Google I/O 2026 Report
- ✓ AI search traffic grew 527% in 12 months — Position Digital AI SEO Statistics, 2026
- ✓ ChatGPT minimum rating 4.30, Perplexity 4.10, Gemini 3.90 — AI local search rating threshold research, 2026

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